

Asynchronous FIFO — CDC Design & UVM Verification

Gray-Coded Pointers, Reset-Aware Scoreboarding, and a Bug-Injection Regression Harness

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PSU ECE 593 — Functional Verification (Team 3)

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The Problem

An **asynchronous FIFO** buffers data between two clock domains that share **no phase relationship**:

- **Write domain** — 80 MHz (12.5 ns period), bursty producer
- **Read domain** — 50 MHz (20 ns period), slower consumer
- 64 entries × 8 bits, no upstream backpressure

A correct implementation must guarantee:

- **Lossless transfer** — every accepted write is read back exactly once
- **Order preservation** — FIFO discipline across the clock boundary
- **Overflow protection** — writes blocked when `wFull`
- **Underflow protection** — reads blocked when `rEmpty`
- **No metastability** — pointer transfers tolerate the unrelated clock edges
- **Immediate flag behavior** — `wHalfFull` / `rHalfEmpty` assert on the threshold transaction, not the cycle after

Simulation with a single clock cannot exercise these obligations. Two unrelated clocks force every CDC hazard to actually occur.

Why an Asynchronous FIFO

Alternative	Why it loses for streaming CDC
Two-flop synchronizer on bare data	Only safe for single-bit signals; multi-bit data corrupts on inconsistent sampling
Bus handshake (req / ack)	Backpressure per word — kills throughput for streaming
Mailbox / single register	No queueing — slow consumer drops samples
Shared occupancy counter	The counter itself is an unsafe shared CDC state
Asynchronous FIFO (this work)	Per-domain pointers, Gray-coded across, queue-depth elasticity

A FIFO turns a CDC problem into a **pointer-synchronization problem** — a problem with a known, provably-safe solution.

CDC Hazards Being Defended Against

- **Metastability** — a flip-flop sampled within its setup/hold window resolves to an indeterminate value; resolution time is exponentially distributed
- **Multi-bit pointer sampling** — a raw binary increment can change multiple bits in the same cycle (`0111` → `1000`). Different bits cross the synchronizer in different cycles → spurious pointer values
- **Unsafe shared occupancy** — a `fifo_count` register written by both clocks has no safe sampling window
- **Reset asymmetry** — write and read domains are reset independently; a naïve scoreboard sees mid-flush state

Design principle: every cross-domain signal must be either a single bit, or a Gray-coded pointer where exactly one bit changes per increment.

System Architecture — Five Functional Blocks

```
asynchronous_fifo (top, Post_M5/UVM/async_fifo.sv)
├── fifo_memory      storage array; gated write/read access
├── write_pointer    binary -> Gray wptr; wFull; wHalfFull
├── read_pointer     binary -> Gray rptr; rEmpty; rHalfEmpty
├── sync_w2r         wptr synchronized into the read clock domain
└── sync_r2w         rptr synchronized into the write clock domain
```

- One module per CDC concern — the synchronizers are **identical reusable blocks** parameterized by stage count and width
- Status flags are produced inside the *consuming* domain so consumers never need to cross-clock the result
- All pointers are **7 bits wide** (`ADDR_SIZE+1 = 6+1`) — the extra MSB is structural, not a debug aid

Design Decision #1 — Binary Locally, Gray Across

Pointer arithmetic stays in **binary** inside each domain (increment, occupancy diff, threshold compare are all trivial). Only the **cross-domain copy** is Gray.

```
// write_pointer module in async_fifo.sv – ports: clk=wclk, rst_n=wrst, inc=winc
assign binary_wptr_next = binary_wptr + (inc & ~wFull);           // local: binary
assign gray_wptr_next   = (binary_wptr_next>>1) ^ binary_wptr_next; // cross: Gray

always_ff @(posedge clk or negedge rst_n) begin
    if (!rst_n) begin
        wptr <= '0; binary_wptr <= '0; wFull <= '0; wHalfFull <= '0;
    end else begin
        wptr      <= gray_wptr_next;           // Gray pointer registered for cross-domain
        binary_wptr <= binary_wptr_next;       // local binary for arithmetic
        wFull      <= full_next;
        wHalfFull  <= half_full_next;
    end
end
end
```

Why: Gray code guarantees exactly **one bit transition per pointer increment**. Even if the destination domain samples mid-transition, the worst case is reading the old value or the new value — never a corrupted intermediate.

Design Decision #2 — One Extra Pointer Bit

The address space is 6 bits (64 entries), but the pointer is **7 bits**. The MSB encodes "lap parity" — how many times the pointer has wrapped.

Write ptr MSB	Read ptr MSB	Address bits equal?	State
0	0	yes	empty
1	1	yes	empty (both wrapped same number of times)
0	1	yes	full (writer one lap behind reader's perspective)
1	0	yes	full

```
// wrap-aware full detection – verbatim from write_pointer in async_fifo.sv
assign full_next = ((gray_wptr_next[ADDR_SIZE-2:0] == wq2_rptr[ADDR_SIZE-2:0]) &&
                    (gray_wptr_next[ADDR_SIZE-1:0] != wq2_rptr[ADDR_SIZE-1:0]) &&
                    (gray_wptr_next[ADDR_SIZE]      != wq2_rptr[ADDR_SIZE]));
```

The three conditions, on the **Gray-coded** pointers, jointly express "lower bits match AND MSB-pair differs" — the Gray-domain equivalent of "same address, opposite lap."

Replacing this with `(gray_wptr_next == wq2_rptr)` is exactly `WPTR_FULLFLAG_BUG` — a real defect the verification environment is required to catch.

Design Decision #3 — Destination-Domain Synchronizers

A two-flop synchronizer must be clocked by the **consumer** of the synchronized signal, not the producer.

```
// async_fifo.sv – verbatim instantiations from the asynchronous_fifo top
sync #(.ADDR_SIZE(ADDR_SIZE)) sync_w2r (          // wptr → read domain: clocked in rclk
    .clk(rclk), .rst_n(rrst), .wData(wptra), .rData(rq2_wptr));

sync #(.ADDR_SIZE(ADDR_SIZE)) sync_r2w (          // rptr → write domain: clocked in wclk
    .clk(wclk), .rst_n(wrst), .wData(rptra), .rData(wq2_rptr));
```

The `sync` module reuses `.wData` / `.rData` as its own port names — they are the synchronizer's input and output, **not** the FIFO's data path. The actual signals being synchronized are the 7-bit Gray pointers.

The subtle trap: if the synchronizer were clocked in the *source* domain, the second flop would still be in the source domain — the destination logic would sample an unsynchronized value and the metastability tolerance evaporates.

This is also where `SYNC_BUG` lives — removing the second flop reduces the MTBF to single-flop levels and the scoreboard must detect the resulting mismatches.

Design Decision #4 — Next-Pointer Half-Flag Timing

Half-full and half-empty are computed from **next-cycle local pointer** vs. **synchronized remote pointer** — never from a dual-clock occupancy counter.

```
// write_pointer.sv - half-full driven by NEXT local wptr (not current)
assign wptr_diff      = binary_wptr_next - binary_rptr_sync;
assign half_full_next = (wptr_diff >= 2**(ADDR_SIZE-1)); // 2**5 = 32 for depth 64

// read_pointer.sv - mirror on the read side
assign rptr_diff      = binary_wptr_sync - binary_rptr_next;
assign half_empty_next = (rptr_diff <= 2**(ADDR_SIZE-1));

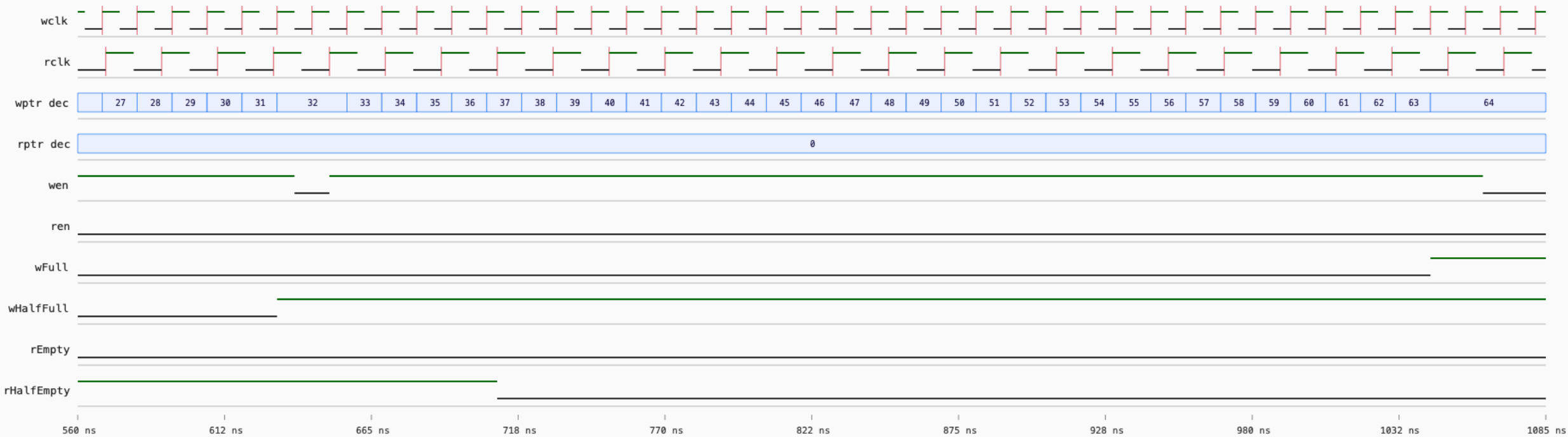
// wHalfFull / rHalfEmpty are then registered from *_next inside the always_ff block.
```

Why this matters: with the *current* pointer the flag asserts **one cycle late** — the threshold transaction has already been accepted before the flag tells you it crossed. Using `*_next` makes the assertion edge align with the accepted transfer.

M3 directed runs exposed the one-cycle-late behavior. Post_M5 fixes it. See Engineering Insight #1.

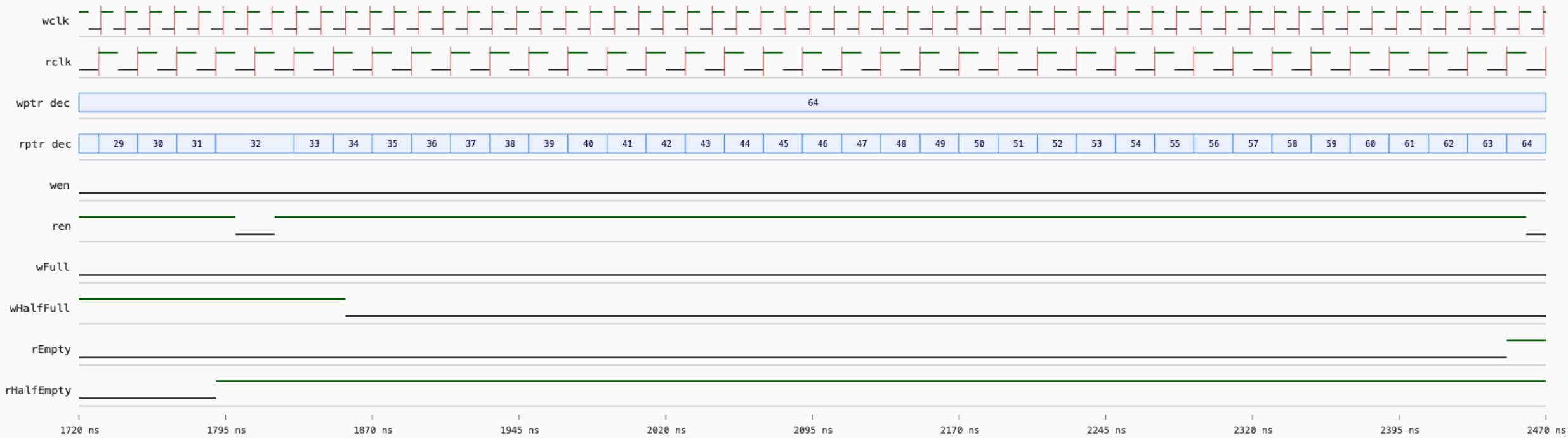
Post_M5 write-side threshold zoom: half-full and full

Red ticks mark rising clock edges. Pointer tracks show full binary pointer values in decimal.



Post_M5 read-side threshold zoom: half-empty and empty

Red ticks mark rising clock edges. Pointer tracks show full binary pointer values in decimal.



UVM Testbench Architecture

```
tb_top (Post_M5/UVM/async_fifo_top.sv)
├── DUT: asynchronous_fifo
├── intf: shared SystemVerilog interface (virtual intf via uvm_config_db)
├── uvm_test_top: fifo_random_test (default) | fifo_base_test (+define+BASE_TEST)
│   └── fifo_env
│       ├── write_agent
│       │   ├── write_sequencer — drives constrained-random wData & winc
│       │   ├── write_driver   — pin-level wclk-domain stimulus
│       │   └── write_monitor  — publishes accepted writes (winc && !wFull)
│       ├── read_agent
│       │   ├── read_sequencer — drives rinc with controllable rate
│       │   ├── read_driver    — pin-level rclk-domain stimulus
│       │   └── read_monitor   — publishes accepted reads (rinc && !rEmpty)
│       └── fifo_scoreboard — reset-aware queue reference model
```

- Two **independent** agents — write/read run on unrelated clocks, both publish to the scoreboard via analysis ports
- The interface is bound to both DUT and TB; **no DUT internals are inspected** by checkers

Race-Free Driver Discipline

The DUT samples `winc` / `rinc` / `wData` on the **rising clock edge**. Drivers therefore stimulate on the **falling edge** so signals are stable before the sampling edge.

```
// async_fifo_driver.sv – verbatim drive_write task
task drive_write (transaction_write txw);
    @(negedge intf_vi.wclk);           // signals settle a half-cycle before posedge
    this.intf_vi.winc = txw.winc;
    this.intf_vi.wData = txw.wData;
endtask                               // returns; DUT samples on next posedge
```

Why: if the driver wrote inside `@(posedge wclk)` instead, two `always @(posedge wclk)` blocks (the driver's and the DUT's) would race in the simulator scheduler. The DUT could sample either the previous or the new value depending on scheduler order — pass/fail becomes a non-deterministic artifact of the simulator. Driving at `negedge` puts a full half-cycle of settling between the change and the sample, eliminating the race and matching how synchronous logic actually receives signals on a board.

Accepted-Transfer Monitoring

The monitors publish **only accepted transfers**, not every stimulus pulse.

```
// async_fifo_write_monitor.sv - mon_write task (verbatim essentials)
@(negedge vif.wclk); #1;                // sample just after the negedge
accepted = (vif.wrst === 1'b1) &&        // not in reset
            (vif.winc === 1'b1) &&        // write attempted
            (vif.wFull === 1'b0);        // and FIFO had room
sampled_wData = vif.wData;
@(posedge vif.wclk); #1;                // wait through the DUT's sample edge
if (accepted) begin
    txw = transaction_write::type_id::create("txw");
    txw.wData = sampled_wData;
    port_write.write(txw);              // → scoreboard analysis port
end
```

Why this distinction matters:

- The test deliberately drives `winc=1` while `wFull=1` to verify **overflow protection** — those writes must *not* enter the scoreboard reference queue, or the comparison desynchronizes
- Same logic on the read side for `rinc && !rEmpty` — underflow attempts are valid negative stimulus, not real reads
- Lets one stimulus stream serve both **happy-path** and **negative** coverage without bookkeeping in the test

Reset-Aware Queue Scoreboard

The scoreboard is an **independent SystemVerilog queue** — it does not look inside the DUT.

```
// async_fifo_scoreboard.sv – essential pieces (verbatim signatures)
transaction_write tw[$];           // independent expected-data queue

function void write_port_a(transaction_write txw);    // analysis_imp for write
    tw.push_back(txw);                               // accepted write → expected
    write_count++;
endfunction

function void write_port_b(transaction_read txr);    // analysis_imp for read
    transaction_write popped;
    if (tw.size() > 0) begin
        popped = tw.pop_front();
        if (txr.rData === popped.wData)
            `uvm_info("ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD",
                $sformatf("PASSED Expected Data: %0h --- DUT Read Data: %0h",
                    popped.wData, txr.rData), UVM_HIGH)
        else
            `uvm_error("ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD",
                $sformatf("ERROR Expected Data: %0h Does not match DUT Read Data: %0h",
                    popped.wData, txr.rData))
    end else
        `uvm_error("ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD", "Read observed with empty expected queue")
endfunction
```

The **reset flush** lives inside `run_phase` (see slide 23) — the default run uses `+define+RESET_SEQUENCE` (periodic resets); without an explicit flush, the queue desyncs from the DUT after the first reset.

Coverage Strategy — DUT-Scoped Only

Coverage is **deliberately scoped to the design under test** — the testbench is not instrumented.

```
# Post_M5/UVM/run.do (verbatim line)
vopt tb_top -o top_optimized +acc +cover=sbfec+asynchronous_fifo(rtl).
```

Flag letter	Meaning
s	Statement coverage
b	Branch coverage
f	Finite-state-machine state coverage
e	Expression coverage
c	Condition coverage

The trailing `+asynchronous_fifo(rtl).` clause says **only this instance** — TB code is excluded.

Why: instrumenting the testbench would inflate the reported number with TB-internal statements. The number that matters is "how much of the DUT did the verification environment actually exercise."

Covergroup Inventory — `async_fifo_coverage.sv`

Covergroup	Bins	Purpose
<code>cg_fifo</code>	<code>winc</code> , <code>rinc</code> , <code>wFull</code> , <code>rEmpty</code>	Basic signal toggle
<code>cg_half_full_empty</code>	<code>wHalfFull</code> , <code>rHalfEmpty</code>	Mid-occupancy thresholds
<code>cg_data_integrity</code>	<code>wData</code> in 4 quartiles	Full data-range exercise
<code>cg_data_patterns</code>	<code>0x00</code> , <code>0xFF</code> , <code>0x55</code> , <code>0xAA</code> on both <code>wData</code> & <code>rData</code>	Walking-pattern stress
<code>cg_burst_ops</code>	<code>winc=1</code> , <code>rinc=1</code>	Pure-write & pure-read bursts
<code>cg_idle_cycles</code>	<code>winc=0</code> iff <code>!winc</code> , <code>rinc=0</code> iff <code>!rinc</code>	Quiet-period sampling
<code>cg_high_freq</code>	<code>wclk=1</code> , <code>rclk=1</code>	Clock-high coincidence
<code>cg_abrupt_change</code>	enable transitions	Sudden producer/consumer rate change
<code>cg_throughput</code>	enable cross-coverage	Sustained simultaneous activity

`cg_reset` is additionally declared in the source for completeness; the canonical farm run reports **9 covergroup types** at 100%.

Instances

Design Units

tb_top (100%)

DUT (100%)

mem_inst

write_ptr

read_ptr

sync_w2r

sync_r2w

fifo_pkg (100%)

Questa Coverage Report Summary

Instance Coverage Summary (100%)					
Coverage Type ↑	Bins	Hits	Misses	Coverage	
Search...	Search...	Search...	Search...	Search...	
Assertions	5	5	0	100%	
Branches	14	14	0	100%	
Covergroups	9	na	na	100%	
Coverpoints/Crosses	19	na	na		
Covergroup Bins	36	36	0	100%	
Expressions	10	10	0	100%	
Statements	43	43	0	100%	

Design Units Coverage Summary (100%)					
☰					
Coverage Type ↑	Bins	Hits	Misses	Coverage	
▼	▼	▼	▼	▼	
Assertions	5	5	0	100%	
Branches	12	12	0	100%	
Covergroups	9	na	na	100%	
Coverpoints/Crosses	19	na	na		
Covergroup Bins	36	36	0	100%	
Expressions	10	10	0	100%	
Statements	38	38	0	100%	

Bug-Injection Framework — Four `ifdef` -Gated Defects

`Post_M5/UVM/async_fifo.sv` ships with **four real defects** behind compile-time macros. They are commented in `run.do` by default; uncommenting any one makes the verification environment **fail loudly**.

Macro	Injected defect	Where	Verification purpose
<code>WDATA_CORRUPTION_BUG</code>	XORs write data with <code>8'hFF</code> before storing	<code>fifo_memory</code>	Scoreboard data-integrity
<code>SYNC_BUG</code>	Removes the second synchronizer flop (single-flop sync)	<code>sync</code>	CDC robustness
<code>RPTR_BUG</code>	Drops Gray encoding on the read pointer	<code>read_pointer</code>	Pointer encoding
<code>WPTR_FULLFLAG_BUG</code>	Naïve equality compare instead of wrap-aware Gray	<code>write_pointer</code>	Lap-parity full detection

```
# run.do – flip exactly one comment to fail the environment on demand
# vlog -source -lint +define+WDATA_CORRUPTION_BUG async_fifo.sv
# vlog -source -lint +define+SYNC_BUG          async_fifo.sv
# vlog -source -lint +define+RPTR_BUG          async_fifo.sv
# vlog -source -lint +define+WPTR_FULLFLAG_BUG async_fifo.sv
```

A passing verification environment is necessary; **an environment that also fails for known defects is sufficient.**

Bug-Injection Evidence — WDATA_CORRUPTION_BUG

Enabling WDATA_CORRUPTION_BUG (XOR write data with 0xFF) produces immediate, repeated scoreboard errors:

```
# Post_M5/docs/transcript_datacorruptionbug.txt (verbatim; identifier prefix elided)
UVM_ERROR async_fifo_scoreboard.sv(65) @ 260:
  [ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD] ERROR Expected Data: 2 Does not match DUT Read Data: fd
UVM_ERROR async_fifo_scoreboard.sv(65) @ 360:
  [ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD] ERROR Expected Data: d2 Does not match DUT Read Data: 2d
UVM_ERROR async_fifo_scoreboard.sv(65) @ 420:
  [ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD] ERROR Expected Data: ba Does not match DUT Read Data: 45
UVM_ERROR async_fifo_scoreboard.sv(65) @ 440:
  [ASYNC_FIFO_SCOREBOARD] ERROR Expected Data: b Does not match DUT Read Data: f4
```

Verify by hand: $0x02 \oplus 0xFD = 0xFF$, $0xD2 \oplus 0x2D = 0xFF$, $0xBA \oplus 0x45 = 0xFF$, $0x0B \oplus 0xF4 = 0xFF$. Every mismatch's xor is exactly the injected 0xFF constant — the scoreboard is catching the bug at the precise xor relationship the code introduces, not by accident.

Milestone Progression — Five Snapshots, One Repository

The repo is organized as a **sequence of frozen verification-maturity snapshots**, not a layered codebase.

Stage	Directory	What this milestone added
M1	M1/ConventionalTB/	Procedural SV testbench; queue-based checking; first <code>\$finish</code> -clean run
M2	M2/CLASS/	Class-based generator/driver/monitor/scoreboard; pre-UVM modularization
M3	M3/CLASS/	Added functional coverage; uncovered the one-cycle-late half-flag bug
M4	M4/UVM/	UVM agents, sequencers, sequences; analysis-port-based scoreboard
M5	M5/UVM/	UVM assertions, bug-injection hooks, refined run flow
Post_M5	Post_M5/UVM/ ★	Canonical: race-free drivers, reset-aware scoreboard, farm evidence, 100% coverage

★ Canonical. Earlier milestones are preserved for grading provenance and to show *how* the methodology evolved — they are not maintained.

Engineering Insight #1 — The One-Cycle-Late Half Flag

Symptom (M3): the directed test asserted that `wHalfFull` should go high when the 32nd write was accepted. Waveform showed it asserting on the **33rd** write — one `rdclk` too late.

Root cause: the original RTL drove half-flags off **current** `binary_wptr`. By the time the next clock edge updates `binary_wptr` to 32, the threshold transaction has already been accepted.

Wrong fix (rejected): "just shift the threshold to 31." This would make the threshold-relative semantics wrong for a parameterized depth — fragile.

Correct fix (Post_M5): drive the flag off `binary_wptr_next` (already computed combinationally for the local increment) compared against the synchronized remote pointer. The assertion edge now coincides with the accepted transfer.

Takeaway: "flag timing off-by-one" is rarely a counter bug — it's a *combinational vs. registered* signal choice. Always ask which side of the flip-flop the flag wants to live on.

Engineering Insight #2 — Reset-Flush Discipline

Tempting shortcut: "disable reset stimulus so the scoreboard logic is simpler."

Why rejected: production hardware can be reset at any time. The FIFO must come back to empty cleanly and the scoreboard must stay aligned with the DUT through it — hiding reset from stimulus also hides any reset-induced bug.

What was done instead: UVM classes can't host `always` blocks, so the flush lives inside `run_phase` as a `forever` loop with an event control — the idiomatic equivalent:

```
// async_fifo_scoreboard.sv – verbatim run_phase
task run_phase(uvm_phase phase);
    super.run_phase(phase);
    forever begin
        @(negedge vif.wrst or negedge vif.rrst);
        if (tw.size() != 0)
            `uvm_info("SCOREBOARD",
                $sformatf("Reset flushed %0d queued expected writes", tw.size()), UVM_LOW)
        tw.delete();
        reset_count++;
    end
endtask
```

The farm transcript reports `Reset flushes: 2` and `Residual expected_q: 0` — the flushes fired and the queue was empty at end-of-test.

Takeaway: when a feature is "hard to verify," verifying it is exactly the point — work around it and the bug ships.

Tooling & Workflow

Tool	Role
Siemens Questa 2021.3_1	Primary simulator (<code>vlog</code> , <code>vopt</code> , <code>vsim</code> , <code>vcover</code>)
UVM (bundled with Questa)	Verification methodology
PSU ECE farm (<code>mo.ece.pdx.edu</code>)	Headless farm runs for evidence capture
<code>~/claude-runs/<UTC-stamp>_<slug>/</code>	Per-run isolation directory on the farm — every agent-driven run is auditable
<code>make_artifacts.py</code> , <code>make_flag_debug_waveforms.py</code>	VCD → CSV → SVG → PNG rendering pipeline; deck images regenerate from real VCDs

Canonical non-interactive invocation:

```
cd Post_M5/UVM
vsim -c -do "do run.do; quit -f" | tee transcript
```

The explicit `quit -f` is mandatory — `run.do` sets `NoQuitOnFinish 1`, so `$finish` halts the simulation but leaves `vsim` at a Tcl prompt forever otherwise.

Final Verdict — Post_M5/UVM/transcript_farm.txt

```
Writes observed      : 659
Reads  observed      : 596
Reset flushes        : 2
Residual expected_q  : 0
Mismatches / errors  : 0
Verdict: *** PASSED ***
```

```
--- UVM Report Summary ---
** Report counts by severity
UVM_INFO      :    29
UVM_WARNING   :     0
UVM_ERROR     :     0
UVM_FATAL     :     0
```

```
DUT filtered instance coverage: 100.00%
TOTAL COVERGROUP COVERAGE:    100.00%
Covergroup types:              9
```

- Warning-clean compile, zero errors, zero fatals — the simulation reached `$finish` on its own
- Reset stimulus exercised twice mid-run with zero residual queue entries
- 100% on both **code coverage** (statement/branch/expression/condition/FSM) and **functional coverage** (covergroups)

Summary — Skills Demonstrated

SystemVerilog & RTL — parameterized modules, generate blocks, binary-to-Gray conversion, `always_ff` reset discipline, wrap-aware comparators, dual-port memory.

UVM — `uvm_component` hierarchy, agents with sequencer/driver/monitor, `uvm_config_db` virtual interface plumbing, analysis ports/FIFOs, factory overrides, `uvm_test_top` selection via `+define+`.

CDC engineering — two-flop synchronizer placement (destination-clocked), Gray pointer encoding, lap-parity full/empty disambiguation, next-pointer half-flag timing.

Verification methodology — independent reference model (queue-based scoreboard), accepted-transfer monitoring, race-free driver scheduling, reset-aware checking, DUT-scoped coverage.

Evidence discipline — farm-reproducible runs, manifest files, parsed waveform CSVs, rendered PNG artifacts in the repo, four `ifdef`-gated bugs that the environment provably catches.

Tooling — Questa flow scripting, coverage merging across runs, headless SSH-based farm orchestration, VCD-to-PNG rendering for review without a waveform GUI.

Questions?

Deep-dive topics ready to discuss:

- The exact Gray-code wrap-aware full detection (`WPTR_FULLFLAG_BUG`)
- How the synchronizer MTBF changes when the second flop is removed (`SYNC_BUG`)
- Reset-flush event ordering and why two `always @(negedge ...)` blocks suffice
- DUT-scoped coverage filtering — why we exclude TB statements
- Farm-side artifact rendering pipeline (`make_artifacts.py`)
- Trade-offs between procedural (M1), class-based (M2/M3), and UVM (M4/M5/Post_M5) testbench architectures

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